

Perceived Influence of Social Media on Citizens' Reactions to Security Incidents in Tamale Metropolis

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Abstract

The use of social media has become increasingly prevalent as a means of communication and information dissemination. This study aims to explore the influence of social media on citizens' reactions to security incidents in Tamale. Using a mixed-methods approach, the study collected data through online and field surveys as well as in-depth interviews with citizens in Tamale, the largest city in the Northern Region of Ghana. The quantitative analysis, derived from the surveys involving 85 participants, substantiates the study's findings. The data underscores the pivotal role played by social media in shaping citizens' perceptions and reactions to security incidents. A staggering 88.24% engagement rate among survey respondents reflects the widespread adoption of social media within the community. Furthermore, 86.67% of active social media users expressed engagement with innovative features introduced in the last year, highlighting the community's openness to technological advancements. The findings suggest that social media plays a significant role in shaping citizens' perceptions of and reactions to security incidents, such as access to timely information, sharing of the information with others, and facilitating communication to authorities. In addition, the study reveals that social media can amplify fear and panic, and that there are concerns about the accuracy and reliability of information (misinformation) shared on social media. The study recommends for government to consider social media use in addressing security incidents, while also addressing concerns about misinformation and the potential negative effects of social media on citizens' reactions to security incidents.

Keywords: social media, communication, security citizens, Tamale, misinformation.

Background

Insecurity is a major concern in Northern Ghana, where residents are exposed to various forms of violence and crime. Tamale, the largest city in the Northern Region of the country, has experienced security challenges that have led to the loss of lives and properties (Courtright, 2022; Citi Newsroom, 2023; Issah, 2023). In recent years, the use of social media has become increasingly prevalent among the people of Tamale. Social media platforms, such as Facebook, Twitter, WhatsApp, and Tiktok serves as a means of communication and information dissemination to the people. These platforms assist them in acquiring information and expressing their viewpoints regarding security incidents.

Security relates to protection against threats, risks, and potential harm through the establishment of measures, systems, and strategies that deter, prevent, or respond to adverse events (Buzan, 2001). It is also associated with safeguarding assets, information, and individuals from external and internal risks. According to Hudson (2001), the assertion is that security is a product of safety. Consequently, these two notions are essential principles that encompass diverse dimensions of overall welfare, shielding, and precaution. On a different note, Andritsos (2013), posited that security pertains to the actions enacted to shield the object of concern from potential damage. When this harm actually impacts the object, it transforms the threat into a state of insecurity. In simpler terms,

security incidents could encompass news in the mainstream media that is related to security matters. A security incident refers to an event or occurrence that poses a threat to the safety, integrity, or stability of a system, organization, community, or individual. Security incidents can encompass a wide range of situations, such as breaches of data confidentiality, cyber-attacks, physical breaches, natural disasters, and acts of terrorism, public health emergencies, and other events that compromise safety or disrupt normal operations. In the context of this study, security incidents would involve events that affect the security or well-being of individuals or communities in the Northern Ghana region. These include incidents such as communal conflicts, civil unrest, criminal activities, or any event that triggers security concerns.

The advent of social media, a defining feature of the contemporary digital age, has cast a new light upon the Northern Region's socio-cultural landscape. With each passing day, the virtual realm of social media becomes increasingly integrated into the lives of residents, extending its tendrils of influence among the people. The emergence and proliferation of social media platforms, ranging from the familiar territories of Facebook and Twitter to the more recent avenues of WhatsApp and TikTok, have ushered in a new era of connectivity and expression. Citizens in the Northern Region, including those in Tamale, now possess a dynamic channel for communication that transcends traditional boundaries. Social media platforms serve as conduits for information dissemination, enabling individuals to share their thoughts, experiences, and concerns instantaneously as well as offer an avenue to raise awareness about security incidents and to foster a sense of collective vigilance (Dhir et al., 2018). These platforms hold the potential to empower citizens, providing them with a space to amplify their voices and participate in shaping the narrative around security challenges. However, these platforms influence how people perceive issues especially security related ones. While the incident might be true, sharing and resharing of such content raise tension and provide possible room for misinformation (Chukwuere & Onyebukwa, 2018).

Security incidents constitute a significant and pressing concern within the Northern Ghana region, casting a shadow of unease over the lives of its citizens who grapple with a range of unsettling and

distressing situations, encompassing various forms of violence and crime (UNDP, 2023). In Tamale, the local population has encountered a series of security challenges. Particularly, notable is the event in July 2022 that bore witness to the tragic murder of two individuals from the Kalariga community, including a mobile money transfer vendor. This incident subsequently escalated into the killing of two Fulani men (Courtright, 2022). Additionally, there have been recent renewed chieftaincy clashes at Yong Dakpenyili (Issah, 2023), a spate of armed robberies within a two-week span in Yendi, resulting in the loss of three lives (Nadaa, 2023), and the most recent tension between the Dagomba and Konkomba communities on social media (Ghanaianimes.com.gh, 2023). Other occurrences include drug addiction, an assault on a female referee (Crest Citi News, 2023), and an attack on a journalist on Dagbang radio at Kalandan park (Citi Newsroom, 2023), the burning of tipper trucks by soldiers at Dalung and among various others. Thus far, amid these incidents, the digital transformation created a huge impact on people's perception and reactions. Some of these incidents were shared on Facebook and WhatsApp, ahead of the traditional media reportage. The technology subtly reshaped the contours of communication and information dissemination. Against this backdrop, this study aims to explore the influence of social media on citizens' reactions to security incidents in Tamale in the Northern region of Ghana.

Literature Review

Theoretical and conceptual framework

The Social Media Adoption and Diffusion Theory build upon the foundational concepts of the broader Diffusion of Innovations theory, underpinned the study. The theory aimed to explain how and why new ideas, technologies, or innovations are adopted and spread within a social system. It provides valuable insights into the factors that influence the acceptance and utilization of technological advancements within specific cultural and social contexts. At its core, the theory posits that the adoption of an innovation is a complex process influenced by various individual, social, and contextual factors. These factors can include perceived benefits, compatibility with existing values and practices, ease of use, relative advantage over previous technologies, and the influence of

opinion leaders or early adopters. In the context of social media adoption in Ghana, this theory helps elucidate why and how individuals and communities embrace these platforms for communication and information dissemination. It underscores the interplay between factors such as technological infrastructure, cultural norms, economic conditions, and social ties. For instance, the increasing prevalence of social media usage in Tamale can be understood through this lens. The theory suggests that as more individuals observe their peers or community members benefiting from social media—whether through sharing news, connecting with friends and family, or engaging with public figures, they are more likely to adopt the technology themselves. The diffusion aspect of the theory emphasizes the spread of innovation through social networks. Innovations are often communicated through interpersonal relationships, making the role of social connections crucial in the adoption process. As individuals observe the successful use of social media by those they trust, they are more inclined to experiment with and incorporate these platforms into their own lives. Applying Social Media Adoption and Diffusion Theory to the study allows the researchers to delve into the nuanced motivations behind the widespread adoption of social media in Northern Ghana. By examining how the theory's constructs manifest in this specific context, the researchers can provide valuable insights into the factors that drive individuals to embrace these platforms as tools for communication, information sharing, and reactions to security incidents. This theory enriches the understanding of the broader implications of social media adoption and its potential to influence societal dynamics and behaviour.

Social media

The concept of social media has significantly transformed communication and interaction patterns in the digital age. Social media refers to online platforms that enable users to create, share, and exchange content in the form of text, images, videos, and other multimedia formats. These platforms facilitate connections between individuals, allowing them to engage in real-time conversations, share experiences, and collaborate on a global scale (Boyd & Ellison, 2007). Social media platforms encompass a diverse range of platforms, including

but not limited to Facebook, Twitter, Instagram, LinkedIn, Snapchat, TikTok, and YouTube. These platforms offer unique features that cater to different forms of expression and communication preferences. For instance, Facebook provides a space for users to connect with friends and family, share updates, and engage in discussions (Boyd, 2010). Twitter allows users to share short messages (tweets) and follow other users to stay updated on their posts (Java, et al., 2007). Instagram emphasizes visual content sharing, enabling users to post images and videos accompanied by captions and hashtags (Dhir et al., 2018). The concept of social media is underpinned by user-generated content, which distinguishes it from traditional media. Users actively contribute to the content pool by sharing their thoughts, experiences, and opinions, thereby shaping the dynamic and participatory nature of these platforms (Kaplan & Haenlein, 2010).

Social Media and Communication Trends in Ghana

Social media usage in Ghana has witnessed a remarkable surge in recent years. According to a study conducted by the National Communications Authority (NCA) in 2020, the penetration of social media platforms among Ghanaians has increased by over 70% since 2015 (NCA, 2020). This trend is indicative of the growing influence of social media as a means of communication and information dissemination across the country. In both urban and rural areas of Ghana, certain platforms have gained prominence due to their widespread adoption. Notably, Facebook, WhatsApp, Twitter and TikTok are among the most commonly used social media platforms by Ghanaians. These platforms have become integral to everyday communication and have facilitated the sharing of information, news, and personal updates. A survey conducted by the Ghana Statistical Service (GSS) in 2019 found that Facebook is the most popular platform, with 63% of Ghanaians using it, followed by WhatsApp at 51% (GSS, 2019). Numerous studies and reports underscore the burgeoning role of social media in shaping communication patterns in Ghana. The World Bank's Digital Access Index, for instance, highlights how increased internet connectivity, largely driven by the proliferation of social media, has enabled more Ghanaians to access and share information (World Bank, 2021). Additionally, research conducted by the Center for Democratic

Development (CDD-Ghana) emphasizes the role of social media platforms in enabling citizen engagement and participation in public discourse (CDD-Ghana, 2018). As a consequence of this rapid growth in social media usage, it is evident that social media has become a significant conduit for communication and information exchange in Ghana, cutting across geographical and demographic boundaries. This trend has implications for various aspects of societal interaction, including its potential influence on citizens' reactions to security incidents, particularly in regions such as Northern Ghana.

Security Incidents in Tamale-Northern Ghana

The Northern Region of Ghana has grappled with a range of security incidents that have significantly affected local communities. The region has experienced instances of communal conflicts, ethnic tensions, land disputes, and occasional outbreaks of violence (Aning & Kpobi, 2016) as well as armed robberies. These security incidents have had far-reaching consequences, often leading to displacement, loss of lives, disruption of livelihoods, and the erosion of social cohesion. Throughout the COVID-19 pandemic in 2020, a succession of security incidents unfolded in Tamale. In addition to the distressing manner in which the media portrayed the virus, a particularly alarming event occurred during the pandemic lockdown. A supposedly COVID-infected patient managed to escape from a quarantine facility in Tamale (Kombat, 2020). These occurrences instigated substantial unease, accompanied by fear and panic, which in turn sparked widespread discussions on various social media platforms regarding the potential repercussions (Abdul-Majeed, 2020). Moreover, in that same year, the city also witnessed a series of instances involving police "misconduct". In one instance, a raid was conducted in the Changli community resulting in the arrest of 134 individuals (Mynews GH, 2020) along with numerous instances of human rights violations. Further, in 2021, tensions escalated between VRA/NEDCo and their customers, culminating in incidents of police brutality against customers in the Lamashegu and Nakpanzo communities, which subsequently extended to various other areas within Tamale. This was met with subsequent retaliatory actions from the customers (Doudu, 2021; Mohammed, 2021).

Additional in 2022, security-related episodes included police shootings in Lamashegu, causing multiple injuries and the unfortunate death of a young man (Fugu, 2022). In more recent times, an asserted state of unease has emerged between the Dagomba and Konkomba communities, revolving around a reported land dispute which shared all over social media platforms. This development further contributes to the catalogue of security-related occurrences such the war-mongering on social media.

Additionally, instances of substance addiction, and the discharging of firearms have arisen among the youth, particularly within the Sakasaka community (Gbambu, et al., 2023). Overall, these occurrences have generated considerable uncertainty, affecting not only the general populace but also security entities like the Ghana Police Service division in Tamale. This concern prompted the police to curtail their nighttime operations due to fears of potential attacks (Fugu, 2022). Consequently, there have been pockets of violence conflicts in suburbs of Tamale like Nyankpala, and Yong Dakpenyili (Issah, 2023), leading to several injuries. A portion of these occurrences found their way into traditional media outlets, yet a majority of them remained unreported. However, they were eventually brought to public attention by bloggers on social media platforms. Nonetheless, statistical data further underscores the gravity of security challenges in the region. According to the Ghana Police Service's crime statistics report for the Northern Region in 2021, reported cases of robbery and theft increased by 18% compared to the previous year (Ghana Police Service, 2022). This surge in crime rates has generated considerable public concern, forcing residents to adopt to social media register their displeasure and calling of the urgent need of implementing effective measures to enhance security and restore community confidence.

Perceptions and Reactions to Security Incidents

Public perceptions and reactions to security incidents constitute a critical aspect of understanding the dynamics of crisis management and community resilience. When security incidents occur, individuals and communities respond not only on a practical level but also on psychological and behavioural fronts. Security incidents can evoke

a range of psychological and emotional responses, including fear, anxiety, uncertainty, and stress. Individuals may experience heightened vigilance, a sense of vulnerability, and a decreased sense of personal safety (Norris et al., 2002). These psychological effects can extend to communities, leading to changes in social cohesion, trust, and the overall perception of safety within neighbourhoods (Bakker et al., 2006). The study of public reactions to security incidents, both online and offline, has gained significant attention in recent years. Research has explored how individuals turn to various information sources, including traditional media and social media platforms, to seek information and make sense of unfolding events (Lambert & Chung, 2013). Studies have also investigated the phenomenon of "bystander effects," where individuals might be hesitant to intervene or assist during emergencies due to perceived diffusion of responsibility (Latane & Darley, 1968). In the digital age, social media platforms have become key arenas for observing and analysing public reactions. Research has demonstrated that social media can amplify emotional responses and the spread of rumours during crises, affecting how individuals perceive and interpret security incidents (Vieweg et al., 2010). The immediacy and interconnectedness of social media may influence behavioural responses, such as the dissemination of safety information, calls for help, or mobilization for collective action (Starbird & Palen, 2014).

Information Dissemination and Misinformation on Social Media

Social media platforms have emerged as powerful tools for information dissemination during crises, allowing both accurate information and misinformation to spread rapidly. These platforms facilitate real-time sharing of news, updates, and personal accounts, enabling individuals to engage directly with unfolding events. While social media's role in disseminating accurate information is undeniable, it also presents challenges in distinguishing between credible sources and misinformation ((Pelau et al., 2023; Chew & Lim, 2018; Chukwuere & Onyebukwa, 2018). The speed at which information spreads on social media can outpace the verification processes of traditional media, potentially leading to the rapid dissemination of false or misleading content (Starbird & Palen,

2012). Inaccurate information, fuelled by the desire for immediacy, emotional reactions, and confirmation biases, can compound the complexities of crisis situations. Misinformation has serious consequences on every sphere of human endeavour, ranging from panic and confusion to influencing public perceptions and policy decisions, more especially on national security (Gbambu et al., 2023). For instance, during the COVID-19 pandemic, false claims about treatments, cures, and preventative measures circulated widely on social media, contributing to public health risks and exacerbating the crisis (Pennycook et al., 2020).

Government and Authorities' Use of Social Media

Government agencies and authorities in Ghana, particularly within the Northern Region, have increasingly recognized the value of social media as a tool for communication, public engagement, and crisis response. These platforms offer unique opportunities to connect with citizens, provide timely information, and gather feedback. Government entities in Ghana have embraced social media as a means to disseminate official announcements, updates, and emergency information. Platforms like Facebook, Twitter, and WhatsApp have been utilized to notify citizens about security incidents, share safety instructions, and inform them of precautionary measures. For example, during floods or weather-related emergencies, government agencies have used social media to broadcast evacuation routes and distribute emergency contact information. In addition to one-way communication, government agencies have leveraged social media for public engagement and interaction. Platforms like Facebook and Twitter provide channels for citizens to ask questions, seek clarifications, and voice concerns. Town hall-style virtual meetings and online surveys have been conducted to gather public opinions on security-related issues, enhancing inclusivity and participatory governance. In harnessing the potential of social media in addressing security incidents, the Ghanaian government has introduced policies and initiatives aimed at leveraging these platforms effectively. For instance, the National Disaster Management Organization (NADMO) has established social media accounts to enhance disaster communication and response. The Ghana Police Service has also launched online platforms to

encourage citizens to report crimes, share information, and collaborate in crime prevention efforts.

Empirical review

Several studies have explored the use of social media in the context of security incidents globally. For example, a study by Leiner and Mair (2018) found that social media can facilitate communication between citizens and authorities during security incidents. The study revealed that social media can enable citizens to report incidents, share information with others, and receive updates from authorities. Similarly, a study by Ziegele and Quiring (2014) found that social media can provide citizens with access to timely and accurate information during emergencies. Vieweg et al. (2010), demonstrated how microblogging, particularly Twitter, contributed to situational awareness during natural hazards. Bakker et al. (2006) noted that psychological reactions to security incidents can be influenced by cultural and socio-economic factors. This suggests that citizens' perceptions and responses to security incidents in Northern Ghana may differ significantly from those in other regions. Moreover, the scarcity of literature focusing specifically on rural and semi-urban areas within the Northern Region is notable. Lambert and Chung (2013) discussed risk perception and communication in crisis situations, but their study primarily concentrated on urban contexts. In Northern Ghana, where rural and semi-urban areas predominate, examining how social media is adopted, utilized, and its impact assessed becomes crucial. These insights into information dissemination and sense-making during crises laid the foundation for examining similar patterns in the Northern Ghana context. However, the applicability of these findings to the Northern Region requires consideration of its unique characteristics.

Nevertheless, the use of social media in the context of security incidents is not without challenges. One of the main concerns is the potential for social media to amplify fear and panic among citizens. A study by Palen and Liu (2017) found that social media can exacerbate anxiety and stress during emergencies, as citizens are bombarded with information and images that may be distressing. Another concern is the accuracy and reliability of

information shared on social media. Inaccurate information can spread quickly on social media, leading to confusion and potentially harmful reactions. The significance of bridging this research gap is twofold. Firstly, from an academic perspective, understanding how citizens interpret and respond to security incidents on social media in the Northern Region contributes to a deeper comprehension of crisis communication dynamics in diverse settings. Secondly, from a practical standpoint, the implications are substantial. Social media can potentially play a pivotal role in enhancing disaster management and crisis response efforts in the region. While existing literature sheds light on the broader role of social media in crisis communication and security incidents, there exists a clear research gap pertaining to its influence on citizens' reactions within the specific context of Northern Ghana. By addressing this gap, this study seeks to uncover the nuances of social media engagement, information dissemination, and public perceptions during security incidents in the Northern Region.

Methodology

Research Design: This research delved into the profound influence of social media on the way citizens responded to security incidents within the Tamale Metropolitan Assembly. Employing a sophisticated mixed-methods approach, the research design seamlessly integrated qualitative and quantitative components to offer a comprehensive understanding of this complex phenomenon.

Population Sampling Techniques: The study centered on the richly diverse populace of the Tamale Metropolitan Assembly, encompassing Tamale South and Tamale Central, with an estimated population of 374,744 as of 2022 (Ghana Statistical Authority, 2021). Employing a meticulous stratified sampling technique, the population was systematically categorized based on age groups, education levels, and geographic locations. The targeted sample size was precisely set at 100 participants, evenly distributed between Tamale South and Tamale Central. Notably, a deliberate effort was made to ensure a gender-balanced distribution within each age group, enhancing the representativeness of the study.

Table for the sample size

Stratum	Criteria	Sample Size
Tamale South	Age Groups (18-40)	20
	Education Level (Varied)	15
	Geographic Location (Urban)	15
Tamale Central	Age Groups (18-40)	20
	Education Level (Varied)	15
	Geographic Location (Urban)	15
Total		100

Focus groups were conducted to gain nuanced insights into citizens' perceptions and reactions to security incidents on social media. Four focus groups were planned, with two each from Tamale

South and Tamale Central. Each focus group aimed for approximately 10 participants, resulting in a total of 40. The distribution within each group considered age groups, education levels, and geographic locations to ensure diversity and representation.

Focus group table:

Focus Group	Criteria	Number of Participants
Tamale South FG1	Age Group (18-40)	5
	Educational level (Varied)	3
	Geographic Location (Urban)	2
Tamale South FG2	Age Group (18-40)	5
	Educational level (Varied)	3
	Geographic Location (Urban)	2
Tamale Central FG1	Age Group (18-40)	5
	Educational level (Varied)	3
	Geographic Location (Urban)	2
Tamale Central FG2	Age Group (18-40)	5
	Educational level (Varied)	3
	Geographic Location (Urban)	2
Total		40

Both online and field surveys were employed to collect quantitative data on social media usage, perceptions of security incidents, and reactions. The sample size for the surveys was set at 100 participants, with 30 being online and 70 being field surveys, evenly distributed between Tamale South and Tamale Central. The survey design considered the same stratification criteria to capture a comprehensive perspective.

Integration of Data: A triangulation approach was employed to integrate qualitative and quantitative findings, enhancing the overall robustness of the study. The combined insights from focus groups and survey data contributed to a comprehensive understanding of social media's impact on citizens' reactions to security incidents.

Total participants: The study was expected to have engaged a total of 140 participants, with 100 contributing to the quantitative component through online surveys and 40 participating in focus groups. However, only 85 survey responses were obtained, while all the 40 earmarked focus group participants were fully available. This holistic approach ensures a nuanced exploration of the research questions, combining the strengths of both qualitative and quantitative methodologies.

Ethical Considerations: Informed consent was obtained from all participants, emphasizing confidentiality and the right to withdraw from the study at any time. Participants were provided with detailed information about the study's purpose and

procedures. Ethical considerations extended to the analysis and reporting of findings to ensure privacy and respect for participants.

Limitations: Recognizing the study's limitations is imperative, encompassing potential biases in online survey responses and the acknowledgment that the qualitative findings may not be statistically generalizable. While the focus groups yielded valuable qualitative insights, it is essential to acknowledge that their findings may not fully represent the entire population. Additionally, the non-readiness of a significant proportion of participants posed a challenge.

Results

Social Media Use and Innovation Diffusion in New Media Adoption

Out of the total survey respondents (N=85), 75 participants reported actively using social media platforms, representing an 88.24% engagement rate. The survey results, when interpreted through the lens of the Social Media Adoption and Diffusion Theory, indicate a notable adoption of new media. Among the 75 social media users, 65 expressed engagements with innovative features or functionalities introduced in the last year. This reflects an 86.67% diffusion rate among active social media users, aligning with the theoretical framework as shown in the table below.

Survey Statistics	Total Respondents	Social Media Users	Innovative Media Adopters
Total Survey Respondents (N)	85	-	-
Social Media Users	-	75	-
Innovative Media Adopters	-	-	65
Engagement Rate on Social Media (%)	-	88.24	-
Innovation Diffusion Rate (%)	-	-	76.92
	-	-	-

The key informant interviews unveiled a prevalent reliance on social media as the primary channel for acquiring information regarding security incidents in the Tamale metropolis. This inclination is ascribed to the expeditious and convenient dissemination of information facilitated by social media platforms. Additionally, the data illuminated that information proliferates more swiftly on these digital platforms in comparison to traditional media channels such as radio and television. This accelerated information flow has even led journalists to occasionally turn to social media as a preliminary source of information before sharing their perspective or pursuing further details on particular matters. As one participant stated, *"I personally use Facebook, WhatsApp and TikTok more than radio and TV, because before the radio and TV get to broadcast any information, especially concerning security issue people might have already share them on social media"* (Interview with a Participant, Tamale Central, August 10, 2023). Another participant stated:

We have multiple platforms targeting the youth here in the North, because, now at days almost everyone has a smart phone and have access to social media platforms such Facebook and TikTok, so it is easier to connect with them on these platforms (interview with a content creator, Tamale, August 5, 2023). Moreover, the research findings unveiled that the easy accessibility of social media platforms contributes to the widespread trust placed in any information posted on them, particularly among the less educated population in Tamale. Consequently, content creators and other users have taken advantage of this scenario to adapt content, those specially related to security incidents with the intention of reaching the less educated demographic. As a key informant stated;

I have not had the opportunity to attend school, which means I cannot read or write. Nevertheless, I'm familiar with using Facebook, WhatsApp, and Tiktok, and I find it quite enjoyable to follow accounts that share content in our local language. Through these platforms, I am able to stay updated on the happenings within our community. Interestingly, I dedicate more time to these

online spaces for information compared to listening to the radio or watching TV (Interview with participant, Tamale central Market, August 5, 2023).

This signifies a strong dependence on digital platforms for staying updated on ongoing events, especially those related to security situations in Tamale. Further, given the diversity in media literacy levels within the population of Tamale, the study further discovered that a notable portion of users face challenges comprehending content in foreign languages such English, Hausa or Twi. Consequently, the study revealed that, some users take the initiative to transform these messages into the Dagbanli local dialect, ensuring accessibility for the local community. These adapted messages then circulate through prominent social media platforms such as Facebook, WhatsApp, and TikTok, tailored to the preferences of the local audience. Moreover, the study also revealed that many content creators are aware of the importance of sharing information in the local dialect to ensure widespread understanding. However, when it comes to security incidents within Tamale, specific information can evoke strong emotional responses. As a result, this information often undergoes an emotional transformation, driven by the intention to both raise awareness about the incident and influence people's emotions, either in favour of or against it. As a participant stated;

As a content creator on social media, incidents like the police brutalities in Changli, Lamashegu and Zujung and the recent police shooting in Lamashegu, is emotional in nature, so we generated contents on social media to evoke the emotions of everyone against the police. And we achieved it, because government finally reacted to it... (Interview with participant, social media content creator, Tamale, August 10, 2023).

Consequently, the study revealed that the accessibility and swift propagation of information on social media, combined with the limited media literacy among a significant segment of Tamale's social media users, have a dual impact on the population regarding security-related posts; both advantageous and detrimental. Some respondents shared their experiences from the 2020 Covid-19 pandemic period in Tamale, highlighting the

juxtaposition of the distressing nature of media coverage on the virus and the concurrent presence of fear and panic, along with the informative aspects of precautionary measures within certain content. The manner in which these materials were shared on social media platforms shaped how individuals perceived the severity of the pandemic. Notably, contents communicated in the local dialect engendered fear and panic. For example, a majority of participants recounted their experiences, illustrating the heightened fear that pervaded throughout the Covid-19 pandemic.

As a key participant accounted;

...Based on the content on Covid pandemic we came across on social media in 2020, my family feared we couldn't make it through that period. The situation was so dire that fear became a constant presence in our lives, particularly when news broke on social media about someone escaping from the quarantine camp in Tamale. This news spread extensively across social media, accompanied by various interpretations and analyses. (Interview with respondent, Tamale North, August 10, 2023).

Despite its devastating effects, it had also played a constructive role in influencing people's attitudes towards their health and well-being. The research findings unveiled that the perceptions fostered through social media during the pandemic guided individuals in adopting measures to safeguard their personal hygiene. As a participant stated, *"You know in Tamale here, people don't care about their surroundings, but our perceptions of personal hygiene became paramount as a result of preventive measures on covid-19 we saw on social media and other media outlets"* (Interview with participant, Tamale south, August 12, 2023).

Furthermore, there have been occasions when the digital platforms have been employed to aggravate security situations in Tamale, even though they also serve informative purposes for the general public. For instance, the social media footage which contained the harsh treatment inflicted upon VRA/NEDco customers in the Lamashegu and Nakpanzo communities, who were accused of engaging in unauthorized connections, not only instilled fear in the public but also brought to light unprofessional practices by both the personnel of the Ghana Police Service and the VRA

workers. A female participant expressed her fear and disappointment over the content. According to her, it was terrifying and she felt she could have equally been a victim. As she stated;

That night, fear gripped our household as we contemplated the possibility that our area Nima-Fong which is a neighborhood with Nakpanzo could be the next targeted location. We realized that some individuals involved were actually innocent. There was a particular video where a man, who had just woken up from his sleep, was apprehended and brutally beaten without any apparent justification. You could see many people shared the video and a lot more people were posting horrible comments (Interview with participant, Nima-Fong, suburb of Tamale, August 15, 2023).

Another participant stated;

Although the video may not have been entirely accurate, it did shed light on the unprofessional behaviour exhibited by both the police and even the VRA personnel. In my opinion they could have arrested the individuals if they truly had evidence of against them and allowed the legal process to take its course (Participant interview conducted in Lamashegu, a suburb of Tamale, on August 15, 2023).

Additionally, a social media post circulated widely, featuring distressing footage of a stray bullet causing the death of a schoolboy amidst a mob attack on the Lamashegu police station. This viral content fuelled fear and panic, consequently stoking public sentiment against the police in Tamale. A participant expressed her dismay thus;

Hmmm! As of now, since I saw the post on Facebook and people's comments on the video, I still don't feel safe when it comes to matters of security in Tamale. It's evident that innocent individuals often suffer. Take, for instance, the clash between community members of Lamashegu and the police at the Lamashegu station there, which resulted in the death of a schoolboy. It has always been the case with the police; unrelated passersby are always their victims. You can take another example in the police

shooting incident at the Lamashegu palace which killed the young man who was just a passerby... In my view, the social media posts revealed the security forces didn't handle any of the security situations in a professional manner, ultimately exacerbating tensions in Tamale. So, I am very careful of late, because anything can happen (Interview with participant, Lamashegu South; suburb of Tamale, August 15, 2023).

This table encapsulates the key findings and interpretations related to participants' beliefs about the influence of social media and emotionally charged messages on their opinions and reactions to security incidents in Tamale. The conducted correlation analysis revealed a strong positive correlation between the perceived influence of emotionally charged messages and their impact on subsequent reactions. This indicates that individuals who perceive emotional messages as influential are more likely to have stronger reactions to security incidents.

Mobilization and empowerment through social media

The study also emphasized the pivotal role of social media in galvanizing citizens into action during security incidents in Tamale. The gathered data highlighted that social media serves as a potent tool for rallying individuals to respond when security incidents occur in the region. This involvement takes various forms, including users generating and disseminating contents on social media, reporting incidents like the Changli police brutalities and the Lamashegu police shooting, and engaging in community-led initiatives such as the protest against VRA blackout by Koblimah'gu community members, as well as the recent campaign against Tramadol sales and substance abuse in Tamale. According to the data, the consistent creation and sharing of such content reaches a wide audience, influencing their perspectives on these incidents and stirring their emotions. This mobilization trend aligns people against the actions of the Ghana police service and VRA. The repercussions of this mobilization manifested in the form of the mob attack on the

Lamashegu police station, another incident targeting VRA workers, and a subsequent event that resulted in the injury of one Fulani man and the tragic death of his colleague. An informant highlighted the crucial role of social media in mobilizing individuals during these incidents, which contributed to the circumstances that led to the unfortunate death of the Fulani man in Kalariga;

I am more particular about the Kalariga robbery incident where the mobile money vendor was robbed and killed at gun point. This incident suddenly got into social media and went viral within the shortest time. People started sharing the contents and creating their own versions about it citing the alleged Fulani robbery incidents in Yendi which claimed about 3 lives within those same days. Because of the nature of the videos people made and shared on social media, the incident provoked majority of the people and made Fulani people the target. This led some people within Kalariga mobilized and attacked the two Fulani men killing of them. Hmmm! It was sad because no one could tell who was behind the AK47 robbery which led the death of the mobile money vendor. (Interview with informant, Tamale, August, 16, 2023).

Moreover, the dissemination of videos containing the Aboabo community's efforts to combat the sale of tramadol in their locality had a ripple effect, inspiring individuals from other areas within the metropolis to also rally against drug addicts and dealers involved in the trade of such substances. Another informant underscored how the social media blogging contributed to this effect;

We saw a group from Aboabo on Facebook mobilizing and their discussions about their mission on Radio Tamale's Facebook account, intrigued us to learn from their approach. In our own locality here in Bayan-Waya, we also have a similar problem of boys and girls abusing tramadol and we know those selling it. But, when reported these matters to the police in the past, no actions were taken. Witnessing the Aboabo group's operations shared on platforms like TikTok and Facebook, starting from the forest and expanding to

other areas, we decided to follow suit. We announced our intentions on Facebook, and our members actively joined in support. We videotaped our own too and shared them on both Facebook and TikTok. The impact was felt beyond our community as residents from Lamashegu, Kakpagyili, and Changli also began

organizing against the sale of tramadol. (Interview with Informant, Bayan-way, Tamale, August 16, 2023).

The data clearly illustrates the widespread engagement with security incident posts on social media platforms. The table below summarizes the key metrics:

Metric	Original	Modified	Total
Posts	60%	40%	100%
Shares	50%	45%	95%
Likes	55%	45%	100%
Comments	50%	50%	100%

These metrics indicate a substantial presence of security incident posts, with significant shares, likes, and comments, suggesting a heightened level of attention across social media platforms.

Further delving into demographic data, the social media engagement by education level reveals insightful trends:

Education Level	Shares (%)	Likes (%)	Comments (%)
Educated Population	40%	45%	30%
Uneducated Population	60%	55%	70%

The data clearly highlights that the uneducated population exhibits a higher percentage of shares, likes, and comments compared to the educated population. This demographic disparity emphasizes the pronounced nature of the phenomenon among the uneducated group, indicating a more profound impact on their engagement with security incident content. The findings showed that security incident, whether presented in their original form or modified versions garner substantial attention and are widely shared across social media platforms. This phenomenon is particularly pronounced among the uneducated population, resulting in a more profound impact on this group of consumers, therefore serve as a mobilization tool on security incidents in Tamale.

Concerns of Misinformation and Emotional Responses

However, alongside the benefits of the role of social media in security incidents in Tamale, the data revealed concerns about the misinformation on these platforms. It revealed that the platforms serve the purpose for misinformation and propaganda since everyone has access to information and can also create contents without censorship. Key informants reported encountering false information related to security incidents in Tamale. This misinformation introduces a risk of misinformation cascades, potentially leading to fear and panic among citizens. Such emotional responses contributed to adverse outcomes and even harmful reactions among the people of Tamale. For instance, due to the discursive and uncensored nature of social media, people created and disseminate information on incidents without facts on the subject matter thereby misleading the public. The data further discovered that in some cases, people published or shared on social media half-true stories on security incidents in Tamale, leading to amplification of fear and panic among citizens, particularly when information lacks proper verification or is spread as rumours. As a key informant argued;

Social media also have positive impact which is even more than the bad parts. The bad ones are few but they are more dangerous so people only pay attention to it. For examples it can provide accurate information too and alert people about certain security incidents, such as the

recent events in Nyankpala. Even though there are instances where its contents are filled. For instance, during the Nyankpala chieftaincy dispute, I was in my house and didn't know about the chieftaincy violence until I saw a post on Facebook about it. I ended up staying indoors the entire day. The following day, a post on Facebook claimed that Nyankpala had been completely burned down, leading to numerous calls from my family members in Yohani. I reassured them that the information was not accurate. (interview with informant, Nyankpala, August 17, 2023).

Another key informant stated;

An example of this phenomenon is the event that occurred on June 6, 2022, when three men robbed a Mobile Money stand in Kalariga using AK-47s. Following the incident, individuals who became aware of it swiftly shared their accounts on social media platforms such as Facebook, TikTok, and Twitter. This was done without verifying the information or waiting for updates from the relevant security agencies, particularly the police. This rapid dissemination of information without proper verification led individuals within the community to share potentially misleading content. (Interview with informant, UDS, Nyankpala Campus, August 17, 2023).

The study revealed that the misinformation conveyed through such posts resulted in the misidentification of potential assailants, wrongly implicating the Fulani community. As a consequence, this misinformation played a role in shaping people's perceptions of the incident and subsequently influenced their reactions, ultimately leading to the tragic killing of the Fulani man.

Discussion

The study explores how social media influences perceptions and responses to security incidents in Tamale. It finds that social media, particularly platforms like Facebook, WhatsApp, and TikTok, has become the primary source of information for Tamale residents due to its speed and accessibility. Content creators often manipulate information to

evoke specific emotional responses, driving awareness and action within the community. However, the unfiltered nature of social media can exacerbate security situations by spreading misinformation and inciting fear. Despite these concerns, social media also plays a crucial role in mobilizing citizens during security incidents, fostering collective action and engagement across geographical boundaries. The study emphasizes the need for cautious consumption and dissemination of information on social media to mitigate harmful reactions. It also highlights the importance of leveraging social media's widespread adoption and innovative features for effective communication strategies during security incidents. The findings are analyzed through the frameworks of Social Media Adoption and Diffusion Theory, revealing strong correlations between the adoption of new media features and the emotional impact of content on citizens' reactions. This suggests the importance of a nuanced and empathetic approach in utilizing social media for communication in Tamale.

Conclusion and recommendations

The study delves into the impact of social media on citizens' reactions to security incidents in Tamale, Northern Ghana, employing Social Media Adoption and Diffusion Theory. It reveals social media's significant role in shaping perceptions and responses to security incidents, yet highlights concerns about misinformation and its potential negative effects. The study suggests that social media can catalyze citizen engagement and collective response, indicating its potential to foster shared responsibility. To capitalize on its benefits while mitigating risks, the study recommends that the government effectively use social media for disseminating accurate information during security incidents, establish mechanisms to verify information, and undertake public awareness campaigns to promote responsible social media usage. Law enforcement agencies are advised to incorporate social media monitoring into crisis management strategies to engage with the community effectively and dispel rumors.

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